“A month ago, I was called up.”

“Called up?”

“*Service du Travail Obligatoire*—my generation’s military service.”

Rose recalled a poster in the train station: red as blood, and in the center, a soldier with a helmet, below him, men in suits. Bold black type at the bottom: *They give their blood. Give your work to save Europe from Bolshevism*.”

“Will you be sent to Germany?”

“Not if I can help it.” He folded his arms over his chest. “I received the letter at my mother’s address last month.”

“What did it say?”

“It ordered me to report to the German Employment Office.”

She’d seen other posters around town seeking volunteers to work in Germany, promoting high salaries and good working conditions, and how it would help bring French soldiers held as prisoners of war home through an exchange. “Can they force you to go?”

“Yes. But I don’t want to go. I won’t answer the letter.”

“Won’t they find you?”

“I’ve been living at the winery. Even my mother doesn’t know where I am. As long as I’m off the books, working for cash, my name stays out of the files. They don’t know where to find me. The winemaker is part of a network I’m in. He doesn’t have enough labor, with so many men still held in Germany as POWs, especially now with the harvest. It works well for both of us.” His face hardened. “How can they send me to work in the country that imprisons my father?”

“I’m sorry,” Rose said. “I thought it was because of me.”

“What?” He shook his head.

“Because I’m just a cleaner.” Rose felt herself shrinking and lowered her eyes.

“You’re an artist.” He touched her chin, coaxing her to meet his eyes. “You’ve got talent. A good eye. To clean is not to be a cleaner. Do you understand?” He withdrew his hand. “Tell me again what you do?”

“I’m an artist,” she said, smiling brightly.

“And to prove how much I believe that . . .” André pulled something from the pocket of his jacket “. . . I’ve brought you a gift.”

“Me?”